

Gaming on Linux

Gaming on Linux has been stuck in limbo for a long time. Publishers don't release games for Linux, primarily because the market is too small, and gamers don't switch to Linux because you cannot play the latest games.

Some publishers like ID and Epic, do release versions of their games that are native to Linux. This is a natural consequence of the robustness of their game engines, which easily run across operating systems. You also know that these publishers are not exploiting the intricacies of the Windows operating system for their benefit, and that they trust the gaming community. Many of the popular games like Unreal Tournament, Quake, Serious Sam, Return to Castle Wolfenstein and Neverwinter Nights are all available natively for Linux.

These and more can be purchased from www.tuxgames.com. There are also a number of third party porters who port games for Linux, and resell them. This means that at least for the present, Linux simply does not support the bleeding edge in gaming – it takes a while before they start appearing for Linux.

One of the biggest setbacks for gaming on Linux has been the monopoly of proprietary standards. Drivers for gaming peripherals and hardware cannot be distributed along with free distributions. The largest gap in capabilities is because of DirectX. Open GL is good, but is not as good as DirectX.

However, there are a number of emulators available that let you play games made for other platforms on Linux. PlayOnLinux, Cadega and Wine are examples. Wine, is, by far, the most widely used (the other two emulators are also based on Wine), but does not work with all the games, and works differently on different computers.

We will cover Wine in more detail later. One of the mainstays of the Linux community has been the openness of the coding, and the collaborative effort on creating software. This holds true for games as well, and a number of games for Linux have come out from the open source community. These games range from first person shooters to flight simulators, and are a completely satisfying experience for a casual gamer. A great resource for a somewhat comprehensive listing of games available on Linux is available at www.happypenguin.org.

There are several reasons why Linux is a better platform for PC